

Editorial

Dear Readers,

When netbooks first emerged, Linux was considered the only viable solution for these devices. However, as it happens all the time with the market tactics of a certain other player, the open source OS has almost disappeared from these devices too. Nowadays, it's become really hard to find a netbook with preinstalled Linux.

So, what's to be done? We can either wait for the market dynamics to change or take matters into our own hands and drive this change ourselves—like we did with laptops in the past. Our persistence in not using that other OS, has made even a heavyweight like Dell offer Ubuntu preinstalled—although not in all parts of the globe! But then, we should continue to campaign. The easiest is to choose the path of format and reinstall!

We can bring the concept of format and reinstall to netbooks too. So, here's an open question: Which distro do you run on your netbook? Ping us, because we'd love to hear from you. Meanwhile, if you're planning to buy one, which brand and model would you like to go for? I guess, you are also wondering whether it would run Linux, if at all!

Currently, the scenario with netbook hardware compatibility is as dicey as it was with laptops, half a decade ago. Things have changed, for the better over the last few years. If we don't get Linux preinstalled on our laptop, we can exercise our rights to format and reinstall, without worrying about whether the hardware will support Linux or not. With respect to netbooks now, our job is to test these devices and flood the Web (and print) with information on netbook models that are Linux compatible.

Okay, it's now time for me to make a confession: after getting an overwhelming number of queries from our readers, we thought it was about time we picked up the topic and did our bit. So, come next month, we hope to present you with a comparison of hardware features, as well as the Linux compatibility of some of the netbook models available in the Indian market. Also, we'll try to analyse which netbook OS is the best fit, as of now.

Talking about OS, as I write this editorial,

Distrowatch has just announced the release of Ubuntu 9.10 RC. The final release is on October 29. Mandriva 2010 is at RC2, with the final scheduled for November 3. If things go as per schedule, by the time you are reading this both the distros should be out. You may wonder if these are possible inclusions for our December issue... Of course, they are!

By the way, openSUSE 11.2 final is scheduled for November 12. Now what do we do about that? Ubuntu fits into a CD, while Mandriva takes up a DVD. Does that mean we'll make you wait for another month for openSUSE? Meanwhile Fedora 12 is also scheduled for November 17 (unfortunately, the date is too late to be considered as a DVD option. Phew!). So, what's in January 2010? Fedora or openSUSE?

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Personally, I wouldn't have wanted to wait for months before laying my hands on the latest distro. And let's face it, these are the BIG ones! A colleague made a suggestion—hike the magazine's price by Rs 10, go for a dual-layer DVD and fit in both openSUSE and Mandriva. Sounds like a deal? You bet!

But why a price hike? Well, that's to cover the additional cost of a dual-layer DVD. And this will only affect those who buy it from the newsstands—the subscribers are safe! Another reason why you should subscribe :-)

With that, I'll stop the self promotion. Hope you enjoy reading the November issue before we come back in December with a blast!

Best Wishes!



Rahul Chopra
Editor, LFY
rahul@efyindia.com